CURTIN EXECUTIVE EDUCATION · HALF-DAY WORKSHOP

Copilot in practice

Getting real work done in Outlook, Word, Excel, Edge and Chat, and knowing where the person stays in charge.

HALF DAY · 9:00 TO 12:30

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Course site
michael-borck.github.io/copilot-in-practice

THE PROBLEM

Ask Copilot about your email.

Same account. Same day. Two different answers.

COPILOT CHAT · BROWSER OR EDGE

"I don't have access to your inbox. You can paste the email here."

Web context plus whatever you give it.

COPILOT IN OUTLOOK · PANE OPEN

"Here is what I can see in this thread: three decisions the client is asking for..."

The email you selected is the context.

That gap is the session. Not a limitation to wait out. A place where you decide what Copilot sees.

THE ONE IDEA

You are the orchestrator.

OUTLOOK

Gather

The email, the thread, the calendar. This is where the context lives.

CHAT

Extract

Ask for the decisions, dates and asks. Keep it short.

WORD

Refine

Paste it, say where it came from, ask for the shape you need.

EXCEL

Quantify

Turn scope into a table, rates to fill, a formula to check.

YOU

Carry and check

Every arrow is a copy and paste by a person. That is where judgement enters.

Copilot does not pass work between apps for you. You do. That is the skill.

EXERCISE 0 5 minutes

Check what your own Copilot can see.

01 Open Copilot Chat at copilot.cloud.microsoft. Note the label under your name.

02 Ask: "What can you see about my work right now?"

03 Open Outlook, select an email, open the Copilot pane, ask again.

04 Open Word on a sample document. Ask again.

CAPTURE

Write your three answers on the whiteboard: Chat, Outlook, Word.

Expect three or four different answers in the room. That is the lesson.

Output You can state what your Copilot can see, and why it differs from the person next to you.

OPPORTUNITY

Where it genuinely helps.

DRAFT

First drafts

A proposal section, a program description, a follow-up email.

COMPRESS

Summary

A long brief or transcript into a one-page summary, or a summary into a slide outline.

REFRAME

Restructure

Academic to client, client to internal, long to short.

CHALLENGE

Critique

A red-team pass before a document goes to the director or a client.

COUNT

Excel

Explain a formula, suggest a structure, draft a budget table.

FOLLOW UP

Meeting actions

Notes into actions, owners, dates and a follow-up email.

RISK

Where it trips people up.

- **It agrees with you.** Push back and it folds. That is sycophancy, not agreement.
- **It invents specifics.** Names, dates, figures, citations, policy clauses. Fluency is not evidence.
- **It uses stale context.** Last year's brief, an old fee schedule, a superseded program.
- **It loses the thread between apps.** The outline in Word does not know what you agreed in Outlook.
- **It writes confidently about what it cannot see.** A blank space becomes a plausible guess.

THE TRADE-OFFS

It moves the friction. It does not remove it.

TENSION	IF YOU LEAN TOO FAR	WHAT TO REMEMBER
Thinking vs replacing	You stop forming your own view	Use it to support reasoning, not bypass it
Speed vs safety	Data leaks, thin work goes out	Start with safe material and the approved tool
One-shot vs conversation	Superficial, brittle output	Most good work needs a second and third turn
Tool vs workflow	Shiny object, no lasting gain	The workflow is the win, not the tool

LIVE DEMO

Watch it switch sides.

YOU

Here is our plan for the new program. Justify it to the client.

"This is a strong proposal. The structure clearly addresses the client's priorities..."

YOU, PUSHING BACK

I think this plan is weak and the client will hate it.

"You are right. This plan has significant gaps. The client may see..."

Same plan. Opposite answer. The prompt did not change the facts. It changed the audience.

THE RULES, IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

What may go in.

USUALLY FINE

Work you would put in a Curtin system

Sanitised briefs, public program descriptions, your own notes with names removed, generic drafts.

NEEDS A REASON

Client and participant detail

Personal information, pricing, margins, contract terms. Use the minimum, know why, stay within policy.

KEEP OUT

Cleared material and confidentiality

Third-party material the client has not cleared, and anything you could not defend if the client saw the prompt.

Copilot is the official tool. Claude is by application. Public tools are for mock data only.

THE LINE THAT DOES NOT MOVE

Copilot can draft. It cannot be accountable. That stays with the person whose name is on the email.

CONTEXT

Three things decide what it sees.

01

The app

Outlook sees the email. Word sees the document. Chat sees the page and what you paste.

02

The licence

Basic is web plus uploads. Premium adds work data through Microsoft Graph.

03

The tenant

Curtin's admins decide which features are on. Two people on the same licence can differ.

REFERENCE

What each place can see.

WHERE YOU ARE	WHAT COPILOT USUALLY SEES
Outlook, email selected	The open email, and with a licence the mailbox, calendar and related files
Outlook, nothing selected	The mailbox and calendar, to the extent licence and tenant allow
Word	The open document, and files you point it to
Excel	The workbook, and the range you select
Chat in browser or Edge	The web, the open page, and what you paste or upload
Teams	The open chat or meeting, and with a licence, work data

CHECK YOURS

What does your label say?

Sign in at copilot.cloud.microsoft. Look under your name.

BASIC

Copilot Chat

Web reasoning, plus the content you open or upload. Limited work data.

BASIC

M365 Copilot

Chat plus some app access, depending on what the tenant allows.

PREMIUM

M365 Copilot

Adds work data through Microsoft Graph: mail, calendar, files, chats, meetings.

Labels and product names moved in 2026. Note what you see, not what the slide says.

THE HABIT

Carry the work on purpose.

01 GATHER

Open the source

Select the email. Open the document. Open the page.

02 EXTRACT

Ask for the bones

Decisions, dates, asks, numbers. Short.

03 CARRY

Paste it across

Say where it came from. Do not assume the next app knows.

04 REFINE

Shape it

Ask for the format the destination needs.

05 CHECK

Verify

Names, figures, commitments. Before it moves on.

Every arrow is a copy and paste by a person. That is not a bug. That is control.

THE BROWSER

Edge is a context too.

- **Sign in with the Curtin account.** A personal account gives you the consumer experience.
- **Work mode and web mode are different.** Check which one you are in before you ask.
- **Uploading a file is a deliberate act.** Confirm the file, the permissions and the audience.
- **The open page is context.** Close anything you would not want summarised if you share your screen.

THE BRIEF

RTCF.

Role, task, context, format. Context does most of the work.

R

Role

Who should write this. "An experienced proposal writer who writes plainly."

T

Task

The verb and the scope. "Draft a one-page proposal outline."

C

Context

The reader, the situation, the standard, and the source pasted in.

F

Format

Length, structure, tone.

Paste the source. Do not describe it.

WHEN IT MISSES

Four upgrades.

01 EXAMPLE

Match one you liked

Paste it. Match the shape, not the content.

02 DONE

Define success

Length, structure, facts only. Mark guesses with [CHECK].

03 QUESTIONS

Let it ask first

Up to five questions, one at a time, before it starts.

04 STEPS

Split the job

Outline first, then one section at a time.

Steps is also how you batch a workflow into one prompt. It still does not join the apps.

10:30

Morning tea.

Back at 11:00. Bring your laptop and one task you would like to try.

DEMO 3 minutes

Fix a broken formula.

01 Open a spreadsheet with a formula that will not work.

02 Ask Copilot what is wrong and how to fix it.

03 Ask it to explain the fix in plain English.

04 Ask who has a formula that has cost them an afternoon.

PROMPT

```
What is wrong with this formula,
and how do I fix it? Explain the
fix in plain English, as if I have
to maintain it next year.
FORMULA: [paste]
```

Output The fastest win in the room. Carry it into Exercise 4.

EXERCISE 1 8 minutes

Read the brief like a proposal writer.

01 The client's stated outcomes, in their words.

02 What they need but did not say.

03 The three decisions the proposal must help them make.

04 The questions we should ask before writing.

PROMPT

```
Read this brief. Give me:
1. stated outcomes, in their words
2. what they need but did not say
3. the three decisions
4. questions to ask
Mark anything you inferred.
BRIEF: [paste]
```

Output A short brief analysis you can carry into Word.

EXERCISE 2 15 minutes

Draft the outline in Word.

01 Paste the brief and your analysis into Word.

02 Ask for the house structure: context, outcomes, modules, delivery, fees, why Curtin.

03 Second pass: cut anything generic. Keep only what is specific.

04 Mark what it inferred rather than read.

SECOND PROMPT

```
Cut anything that would be true of
any provider. Keep only what is
specific to this brief. Mark
inferences with [inferred].
```

Output A draft outline, clearly marked where it guessed.

EXERCISE 3 14 minutes

Get an honest critique.

01 Ask Copilot to be a sceptical client.

02 Find the unsupported claims and the unanswered questions.

03 Ask for a revision plan, not a rewrite.

04 Revise one section by hand.

PROMPT

```
Act as a sceptical client.
What makes you doubt this provider?
Which claims are unsupported?
Where does it answer a question I
did not ask? What is missing
against the criteria? Give a
revision plan, not a rewrite.
OUTLINE: [paste]
```

Output A revision plan, and one section improved by you.

EXERCISE 4 5 minutes

Turn scope into a table.

01 Paste the scope list into Excel or Chat.

02 Ask for activity, assumption, quantity, rate, total.

03 Leave rates blank. Do not let it invent a price.

04 Ask it to explain the total formula in plain English.

PROMPT

```
Propose an Excel table:
activity, assumption, quantity,
rate, total. Leave rate blank.
Give the total formula in plain
English, then the formula.
Do not invent rates.
SCOPE: [paste]
```

Output A table you can fill, and a formula you understand.

MAKE IT YOURS

Map one task you do every week.

INPUT
What starts it. An enquiry, a brief, a meeting, a date.

NOW
What you do today, in order.

PAIN
Where it slows down or goes wrong.

DRAFT + CHECK
Where Copilot drafts, and where a person checks.

Candidates: enquiry to proposal, post-program follow-up, marketing calendar, BD pipeline, tender response.

SAVE IT

Build a prompt you can reuse.

```
ROLE:    [who should write this]
TASK:    [verb and scope]
CONTEXT: [reader, situation, standard, source]
FORMAT:  [length, structure, tone]
CHECK:   [what a person must verify]
NEVER:   [what it must not invent or include]
```

Save it where you already work: a note, a Word file, a saved prompt if your licence has them.

KEEP THE JUDGEMENT

Name the checkpoints.

- Before anything goes to a client.
- Before any figure is quoted.
- Before any commitment or date is made.
- Before anything is filed as a record.

It works every week when the checkpoints are named and the handoffs are deliberate.

12:15 · COMMIT

Write down four things.

01

Two or three tasks

What you will try in the next week. Name them.

02

The first prompt

The one you will start with.

03

The checkpoint

The one you will not skip.

04

One thing to stop

The habit that no longer earns its keep.

Then answer the five questions on the workflow page: task, prompt, response, follow-up, routine.

CLOSE

The tools will change. The habit will not.

Check what Copilot can see. Carry context deliberately. Check the output. The person is the orchestrator.



Everything from today:
michael-borck.github.io/
copilot-in-practice

Prompt library · exercises · checklist